

Symmetry test

All the pieces in the series in a single document, in reading order. Updated 15 July 2026.

Five cases, five different states, the same question: what happens when a state supports, funds or protects those who violate international law? The rule must apply to everyone.

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Yemen: 73 UN staff still arbitrarily detained by the Houthis, as Hodeidah bleeds again

«These actions violate international law, cause deep suffering to families.» — António Guterres, UN Secretary-General, 12 June 2026

THE FACTS

On 5 July 2026, Houthi fighters attacked Yemeni government force positions in the Hodeidah region (Hays area), on the Red Sea coast, using mortars, drones and sniper fire: 16 soldiers killed and 22 wounded, according to medical and military sources cited by Al Jazeera — the fiercest clashes in years along a frontline frozen since 2022. The same day, a commercial vessel was attacked off Hodeidah, with no claim of responsibility. In parallel, and over a longer period: as of 12 June 2026, 73 United Nations staff — all Yemeni nationals — remained arbitrarily detained by the Houthi de facto authorities, as part of an arrest campaign that began in May 2024 and has never concluded; one World Food Programme worker died in Houthi custody on 11 February 2025. On 29 January 2026 the WFP announced it was terminating the contracts of all 365 of its staff in Houthi-controlled northern Yemen — where 70% of the country's humanitarian need is concentrated — explicitly citing the operating environment made unsafe by arbitrary detentions. On 27 January 2026 the UN Security Council voted a final extension, to 31 March, of the mission supporting the Hodeidah Agreement (UNMHA), which was then shut down: the United States pushed for its closure, arguing Houthi obstruction had made it ineffective; China and Russia voted to keep it. In the background, 21.6 million people remain in need of assistance (11 million children), 4.5 million are displaced, and the 2026 UN humanitarian appeal of \$2.16 billion was only 29% funded in 2025.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

The arbitrary detention of UN staff — often without a warrant, with cases of enforced disappearance lasting months and one death in custody never clarified — violates [Article 9 of the International Covenant on Civil and Political Rights](#) (no one shall be subjected to arbitrary arrest or detention), to which Yemen has been a state party since 1987, as well as the immunities recognised for UN personnel acting in their official capacity. The systematic obstruction of humanitarian access — which already forced the WFP to suspend operations in Saada governorate — falls instead within the scope of the [Geneva Conventions](#) and their Additional

Protocol II, which prohibit impeding humanitarian relief to civilians in non-international armed conflicts. The two violations are distinct but reinforce one another: those who should guarantee access to aid are detained, and in doing so the very crisis that access should relieve is worsened.

IMPLICATIONS — THE SYMMETRY TEST

The principle — humanitarian personnel are not arbitrarily detained, relief access is not obstructed — applies to the Houthis exactly as it would to any other actor this site has already covered. But Yemen has no single culprit, which is what makes it a textbook case for symmetry: the Saudi-led coalition has conducted more than 25,000 air strikes since 2015 and caused nearly 19,000 civilian casualties according to the Council on Foreign Relations; the United Arab Emirates is accused by Riyadh of having armed the Southern Transitional Council's secessionist bid between December 2025 and January 2026, later repelled by pro-Saudi forces; the United States and the United Kingdom have struck Houthi targets directly since 2024. Applying the criterion only to the Houthis because they are the most visible actor at this moment — while staying silent on the coalition, the Emirates, and the Anglo-American strikes — would not pass the test.

APPENDIX: THE "ROUGH RIDER" CAMPAIGN AND THE SA'ADA STRIKE (MARCH-APRIL 2025)

An earlier episode, documented but not yet covered on this site, deserves reconstruction here because it sheds direct light on the symmetry principle applied above. Between March 15 and May 6, 2025, the United States conducted a campaign of air and naval strikes against Yemen, codenamed "Operation Rough Rider," in response to Houthi attacks on commercial shipping in the Red Sea: according to estimates by the independent organization Airwars, the US strikes killed at least 224 civilians.

On April 28, 2025, a US air strike hit a migrant detention centre in Sa'ada, north-western Yemen, killing and injuring dozens of African migrants held there by Houthi authorities. An Amnesty International investigation concluded that the strike constitutes an indiscriminate attack, to be investigated as a possible war crime. Asked by Amnesty, US Central Command (CENTCOM) said it was "assessing all reports of civilian harm" from that period; by the end of 2025 the results of that assessment had not been made public.

In the same timeframe, the Houthis resumed missile and drone attacks on Israel — a missile injured 4 people near the main terminal of Ben Gurion airport (May 4, 2025), a drone injured over 20 people near a hotel in Eilat (September 24, 2025) — alongside attacks on commercial

shipping in the Red Sea, sinking two vessels (Greek-owned, Liberian-flagged) and killing at least three crew members.

Sources (appendix): [Amnesty International](#)

Sources: [Human Rights Watch](#) · [UN News](#) · [UN Secretary-General statement](#) · [Al Jazeera](#) · [Security Council Report](#) · [Congressional Research Service](#) · [CFR Global Conflict Tracker](#) · [Cairo Institute for Human Rights Studies](#) · [ICCPR official text \(OHCHR\)](#)

Mali: army and Russian Africa Corps mercenaries arrange a corpse into a swastika after killing four civilians

«When you find a human being cut up to form a Nazi symbol, by a regular army, it's truly shocking.» — local witness quoted by RFI

THE FACTS

On June 23, 2026, near Timbuktu, a joint patrol of the Malian army and Russia's Africa Corps (the organization that replaced the Wagner Group after Yevgeny Prigozhin's death) passed through the villages of Zarho and Abakoïra, at the border of the Timbuktu and Gao regions. After the patrol passed, residents found four civilians killed: two Tuareg at Zarho and two Songhai at Abakoïra, the latter struck by a drone attack while riding a motorbike. The dismembered body of one of the Tuareg men was arranged into the shape of a swastika on the sand, his severed head placed at the center of the limbs.

Local sources and the Malian human rights collective CD-DPA confirmed that the victims were herders known in the community, with no ties to armed groups. CD-DPA's secretary general, Tilla Ag Zeini, described the incident as a violation of humanitarian law designed to terrorize the population. Neither the Malian army nor the Africa Corps has publicly commented on the incident, despite the latter posting regularly on social media after other operations.

The same day, the al-Qaeda-linked jihadist group JNIM claimed a separate attack on a joint army-Africa Corps convoy in the Kayes region, reporting six dead — a distinct episode but indicative of the intensity of the conflict on multiple fronts in the same country on the same day.

The political context: the military junta led by Colonel Assimi Goïta expelled French forces and ended the UN peacekeeping mission MINUSMA, replacing them with Russian mercenaries — a choice presented to the population as a recovery of sovereignty. As this site already reported in [Burkina Faso leaves the International Criminal Court while remaining the world's country most affected by terrorism](#), Mali withdrew — together with Burkina Faso and Niger — from the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court (September 2025), explicitly removing itself from the jurisdiction of the very court that could investigate episodes like this one.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

The outrage upon the personal dignity of corpses and the killing of civilians without distinction from military targets violate Common Article 3 of the [Geneva Conventions](#) and customary international humanitarian law applicable to non-international armed conflicts. The staging would fall under "outrages upon personal dignity," prosecutable as a war crime under Article 8 of the [Rome Statute](#) — a statute from which Mali has just withdrawn, making the risk of impunity concrete.

IMPLICATIONS — SYMMETRY TEST

This site has already condemned elsewhere the presence and conduct of Russian-linked paramilitary forces; the same standard applies here, with no discount for the fact that the victim is a Malian herder rather than an internationally prominent figure. But responsibility is not one-directional: the patrol was joint — regular Malian army and Africa Corps together — and neither has commented on or condemned what happened. Mali's withdrawal from the Rome Statute, precisely as episodes like this multiply, is itself a political act that deserves condemnation regardless of who physically carried out the killing.

Sources: [Euromaidan Press](#) · [Modern Ghana](#) · [UNITED24 Media](#) · [UA.News](#)

Israel allowed and encouraged Qatari funding of Hamas for years — a month before October 7 it asked for more

«Whoever is against a Palestinian state should be in favor» of transferring funds to Gaza. — Benjamin Netanyahu, Likud party meeting, March 2019

THE MECHANISM: HOW IT WORKED, MATERIALLY

From 2018 until October 7, 2023, Qatar transferred cash to Gaza — physically, in suitcases, through the Israeli Erez crossing — peaking at around \$30-35 million a month. The first shipment, \$15 million, arrived in November 2018. According to Israeli sources, Qatar itself asked Netanyahu to put his funding requests in writing, anticipating he might later deny authorizing them. He did not: the Israeli security cabinet meeting that approved the mechanism, in August 2018, is documented, as is the cross-agency support maintained over the years by the IDF, military intelligence, Shin Bet, Mossad and the National Security Council.

THE STRATEGIC LOGIC: WHY, NOT JUST HOW

Netanyahu publicly justified the operation as humanitarian necessity — "preventing a disaster in Gaza." But his own March 2019 statement at a party meeting reveals a different calculation: keeping Gaza under Hamas and the West Bank under the Fatah-led Palestinian Authority would prevent any unified Palestinian national movement — and therefore any real possibility of a Palestinian state. Retired Israeli general Shlomo Brom summarized the logic: "One effective way to prevent a two-state solution is to divide the Gaza Strip from the West Bank." The choice had a precise origin: after the 2014 Gaza war, Netanyahu rejected a Saudi offer to rebuild the Strip by removing Hamas and replacing it with the Palestinian Authority — a deal that would have normalized relations with Riyadh — opting instead for the Qatari funding channel, despite repeated Mossad warnings.

HOW THE MONEY REACHED THE WEAPONS: THE FUNGIBILITY MECHANISM

Between 2012 and 2018 Qatar funneled roughly \$1.1 billion into Gaza, officially earmarked for state salaries, fuel, and humanitarian aid. No one claims those funds went directly to Hamas's military wing — but, as a retired senior CIA analyst explained to the New York Times, "money is fungible: anything Hamas didn't have to pay out of its own budget freed up its own funds for

other things." It's the same principle by which funding an organization's civilian expenses lets it divert its own resources to whatever that external funding doesn't cover — in this case, according to a Shin Bet investigation published in March, the tunnel network and arsenal used on October 7, 2023.

THE ATTEMPT TO BURY ACCOUNTABILITY

In June 2022, Mossad chief Yossi Cohen publicly called the Qatari channel "a blessing." A month before October 7, in September 2023, Israeli officials met with Qatar's envoy to Gaza, Mohammed al-Emadi, to ask not for a reduction but for an increase in transfers. After the attack, Netanyahu blocked the formation of a state commission of inquiry into the political-security failures that made it possible, and removed Shin Bet chief Ronen Bar, who had requested that commission — a removal Israel's Supreme Court ruled "unfair and unlawful."

LEGAL COMMENTARY

This episode does not constitute a single isolated violation of a specific treaty, but falls within the general obligation of states to prevent the financing of terrorist organizations, enshrined in UN Security Council Resolution 1373 (2001). Here the obligation was not violated through negligence, but knowingly suspended for declared political calculation — according to the Israeli prime minister's own admission, not an external reconstruction.

IMPLICATIONS — SYMMETRY TEST

This site has already condemned, without exception, the financing of non-state armed actors when that financing turned against the sponsors themselves or against third-party civilians. In [Yemen: 73 UN staff still arbitrarily detained by the Houthis, as Hodeidah bleeds again](#), we documented how Iran, through the Houthis, supports a proxy that now acts according to its own autonomous agenda — attacks on commercial shipping, missiles against Israel — well beyond Tehran's original mandate. In [Mali: army and Russian Africa Corps mercenaries arrange a corpse into a swastika after killing four civilians](#), we showed how Russia uses a paramilitary actor — the former Wagner Group — that commits systematic violations without Moscow answering for it directly.

The same standard applies here. The fact that October 7's ultimate victims were Israeli citizens does not exempt Israel from having chosen, knowingly and for declared political calculation, to financially fuel the organization that then carried out the massacre — nor from having subsequently tried to obstruct the accounting of its own political responsibility for it. A note of methodological honesty: the history of US sponsorship of proxies that later turned against their

own sponsors (from the Afghan mujahideen onward) would deserve the same treatment — a piece of its own, with facts verified one by one, not yet published on this site.

Sources: [The Times of Israel](#) · [The Times of Israel](#) · [CNN](#) · [Seattle Times](#) · [Haaretz](#) · [The Jerusalem Post](#) · [TIME](#) · [+972 Magazine](#)

The United States armed the Syrian rebellion for five years, then shut down the program as a gift to Putin

«It is a momentous decision. Putin won in Syria.» — anonymous US official quoted by *The Washington Post*, July 2017

THE MECHANISM: HOW IT WORKED, MATERIALLY

From 2013 to 2017, the CIA ran "Timber Sycamore," a secret program to arm, train, and fund "moderate" Syrian rebel groups against the government of Bashar al-Assad. The program operated from two operations centers — one in Jordan (Amman), the other in Turkey (Gaziantep and Antakya) — where officials from Saudi Arabia, Qatar, France, and the United Kingdom shared space with the CIA. Weapons — AK-47 rifles, mortars, RPG rockets, TOW anti-tank missiles, night-vision equipment — were mostly purchased in the Balkans and Eastern Europe and shipped through Taşucu (Turkey) and Aqaba (Jordan). By some estimates, the CIA trained roughly 10,000 fighters over the course of the program, at a total cost exceeding one billion dollars.

THE STRATEGIC LOGIC

The program originated in 2012, proposed by CIA Director David Petraeus, and was secretly authorized by President Obama in 2013. Its stated goal was to weaken Assad without direct US military involvement, leaning on a consortium of regional allies — Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Turkey — who funded and armed rebel groups in parallel with the CIA, often with weapons already in circulation even before the program's official 2012 launch.

THE VETTING FAILURE: WHERE THE WEAPONS ENDED UP

The "vetting" process for rebel groups, meant to prevent weapons from falling into jihadist hands, did not work. A three-year study funded by the European Union and the German government found that the arming efforts of the US and its allies had "significantly augmented the quantity and quality" of weapons available to the Islamic State. Officials from Jordan's General Intelligence Directorate made millions of dollars diverting program weapons to the black market. Many of the armed groups supported turned out to have ties to al-Qaeda or Salafi-jihadist networks — precisely the risk that "vetting" was meant to prevent.

THE PROGRAM'S END: AN EXPLICIT GIFT TO PUTIN

In mid-June 2017, Trump decided to end the program after a meeting with CIA Director Mike Pompeo and National Security Adviser H.R. McMaster — days before his first meeting with [Vladimir Putin](#) at the G20 in Hamburg (July 7). The Washington Post revealed the decision on July 19, quoting an official who called it an explicit signal to Moscow to improve bilateral relations. Trump indirectly confirmed the secret program's existence by attacking the Washington Post's coverage on Twitter, calling the payments to Syrian rebels "massive, dangerous, and wasteful" — effectively publicly declassifying an operation never officially acknowledged.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

Support for non-state armed groups engaged in another state's internal conflict raises direct questions regarding the principle of non-intervention enshrined in customary international law and the UN Charter. The International Court of Justice, in [Nicaragua v. United States](#) (1986), already established that financing and arming irregular forces against a third-party government constitutes a violation of the principle of non-intervention, regardless of the nature of the targeted government.

IMPLICATIONS — SYMMETRY TEST

This site has already documented, for Iran ([Yemen: 73 UN staff still arbitrarily detained by the Houthis, as Hodeidah bleeds again](#)), Russia ([Mali: army and Russian Africa Corps mercenaries arrange a corpse into a swastika after killing four civilians](#)), and Israel ([Israel allowed and encouraged Qatari funding of Hamas for years — a month before October 7 it asked for more](#)), the same pattern: a state sponsors a non-state armed actor for strategic calculation, and that actor partly or entirely escapes the sponsor's control, with consequences falling on third-party civilians. Timber Sycamore applies the same pattern to the United States: weapons purchased with US public funds ended up, according to an independent EU-funded study, in the Islamic State's arsenal. The fact that the program was shut down not because of its humanitarian consequences or the vetting failure, but as a gesture of détente toward Russia, confirms that geopolitical logic always prevailed over the assessment of real consequences on the ground — exactly as in the three cases already documented.

Sources: [The Washington Post](#) · [Reuters](#) · [Al Jazeera](#) · [NBC News](#) · [Modern War Institute, West Point](#) · [Irregular Warfare Initiative](#)

Four European Court rulings condemn Poland, Romania, Lithuania, and Macedonia for hosting secret CIA prisons — no one in the United States has ever answered for that torture

«The treatment inflicted by the CIA rendition team was of sufficient severity to amount to torture... with premeditation, the aim being to cause severe pain or suffering in order to obtain information, inflict punishment or intimidate the applicant.» — European Court of Human Rights, El-Masri v. Macedonia, December 13, 2012

THE FACTS: FOUR CASES, ONE PROGRAM

Between 2012 and 2018, the Grand Chamber and sections of the European Court of Human Rights (ECtHR) issued four rulings establishing, in procedural detail, the complicity of four European states in the CIA's secret detention and torture program in the decade following September 11.

The most striking case — mistaken identity: Khaled El-Masri, a German citizen mistaken for an al-Qaeda member due to a name mix-up, was arrested at the Macedonian border on December 31, 2003, held incommunicado for 23 days in a Skopje hotel, then handed over to a CIA rendition team at the airport — where he was violently assaulted, hooded, and flown to Afghanistan to a prison known as the "Salt Pit." He remained detained there for roughly four months, until the CIA itself realized the case of mistaken identity. On December 13, 2012, the Court unanimously found the facts proven "beyond reasonable doubt," classifying the episode as enforced disappearance and torture, with direct responsibility falling on Macedonia.

The sites in Poland, Romania, and Lithuania: Abd al-Rahim al-Nashiri (suspected in the USS Cole bombing) and Abu Zubaydah (believed to be a senior al-Qaeda member) were held at a secret CIA facility in Poland between 2002 and 2003. On July 24, 2014, the Court found that Poland had violated Articles 3 (prohibition of torture), 5 (liberty), 6 (fair trial), 8 (private life), and 13 (effective remedy) of the European Convention, ordering it to pay €100,000 to each man. In 2018 the Court issued nearly identical rulings against Romania (where al-Nashiri was held

from 2004 to 2005) and Lithuania (where Abu Zubaydah was held from 2005 to 2006), ordering them to pay €100,000 and €100,000 plus €30,000 in costs, respectively.

The most unsettling detail: before arriving in Poland, Abu Zubaydah had been held at a CIA black site in Thailand in 2002, where — as established — he was subjected to waterboarding. That facility was run by Gina Haspel, who in 2018 was appointed Director of the CIA — the same institution that had run the torture program.

LEGAL COMMENTARY

The ECtHR rulings establish direct violations of Article 3 of the European Convention (an absolute prohibition on torture, non-derogable under any circumstances) and the [UN Convention against Torture \(CAT\)](#). In all four cases, the Court found that the host states knew — or should have known — what the detainees would be subjected to, making them directly responsible for the torture suffered on their own territory, not merely for logistical hosting.

IMPLICATIONS — SYMMETRY TEST

This site has already documented, for Iran ([Yemen: 73 UN staff still arbitrarily detained by the Houthis, as Hodeidah bleeds again](#)), Russia ([Mali: army and Russian Africa Corps mercenaries arrange a corpse into a swastika after killing four civilians](#)), Israel ([Israel allowed and encouraged Qatari funding of Hamas for years — a month before October 7 it asked for more](#)), and the United States ([The United States armed the Syrian rebellion for five years, then shut down the program as a gift to Putin](#)), how geopolitical calculation systematically prevails over the assessment of real consequences. Here the pattern applies to direct torture, not an armed proxy: the United States ran a systematic torture program, four European governments — not regimes commonly targeted by this site's accusations, but Western democracies — actively collaborated in it, and the woman who ran one of the harshest sites was later promoted to lead the very agency. No CIA official has ever been prosecuted in the United States for these acts; the accountability established by courts so far falls only on the European states that hosted the sites, not on those who ordered and carried out the torture itself.

Sources: [HUDOC — European Court of Human Rights](#) · [Open Society Justice Initiative](#) · [Human Rights Watch](#) · [BBC](#) · [Lieber Institute, West Point](#)